Life Support

By Stephanie Summerville

NOTE: Narrator should be African American

(Pg 358-365) It was the 1980s and I finally got up the nerve to look for a job. I got excited because the new thing was to have home health-care aides -- people who would sit with the elderly, feed them, give them their medicine and things like that. So when I opened up the newspaper and saw it, it was a hallelujah moment: ***Ahh! Sitter! I can do this job. What better job than just sitting?***

So I went to this temp agency called Health Skills. They gave me my first assignment. On the first day, I walk up to this house on cinder blocks in a working-class, all-white neighborhood. I knock on the door, and I see this woman peer out.

WOMAN: *(peering through a partially open door and in blatant disgust)* Go away!

And so I say, ***"Hi, ma'am. I'm here from Health Skills. I'm here because you needed a sitter."*** I think that will help, but she says.

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WOMAN: Go away! I don't want you here!

She goes to the phone, and she calls the company! I'm standing outside and I'm waiting on her to get through this phone call, and finally she just slams down the phone, comes to the door and lets me in.

INTRODUCTION

In the US, health care workers take an oath to treat all patients equally, but that's not always the case. According to numerous studies, members of the Black community experience more illness, worse outcomes and premature death compared to their white counterparts. In addition to disparities in income, housing and education, inherent racial bias also occurs in our healthcare system. That racial bias—whether conscious or not—can lead to prejudicial behavior.

And while we have made tremendous progress from the days of the Civil War, we still have work to do; to eliminate these disparities and to discover that regardless of the color of our skin, we are human and deserve grace.

Life Support by Stephanie Summerfield.

So I am walking through this house. You have to walk through the living room and kitchen to get to the bedroom, so you can see all the way through the house. Well, I get to the bedroom, and I am hit with this horrible stench. The air

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is filled with the smell of bile, and there's this man lying on a hospital bed in an otherwise normal-looking bedroom. He has breathing tubes and IVs and he's completely unconscious. And the breathing machine is working, and it's pumping up this brown mousse out of his mouth and nose. It kind of looks like styling foam. *(looking at a healthcare chart)* And what I discover is that this man is dying of cirrhosis of the liver. In the final stages the liver and bile are breaking down, building up as fluid in the lungs, and the body is trying desperately to get rid of that so that he can breathe. So that's what's coming up out of his mouth and nose. Every fifteen minutes this process goes through, and I have to stand there and clean it up. So me being an overachiever and wanting to do well, I throw myself into the job. This woman who let me in is very aggressive. She doesn't say anything, but she's not very kind to me.

So we clean up this man, and there's nothing for me to do but to just wait. So I say, ***"Maybe I should just sit down."*** And this woman, she's staring at me with hate pouring from her eyes. I don't know what I've done. I've just done my job, and I've done it pretty well. So I look at her, and I say, ***"Look, I can get this, I'm fine now."***

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She turns around, doesn't say a word to me, and walks right back down that hallway and sits on the couch. And even though she's sitting across from the TV, she's sitting in profile so she can see down the hallway, and she's staring at me -- she's got her eye on me.

I sit down, and I'm looking around the room, and it's filled with this nice Shaker furniture, and it's got a floor-to-ceiling Confederate flag behind the man's bed.

And I have to tell you, it takes a little while for the gears to kick in. I'm taking in the furniture -- there's a lovely armoire, and I'm so Martha Stewart, I'm into decorating and everything. And they have a little coat tree, and on the coat tree there's this beautiful robe. Kind of like a church robe except it's white, and it has a round circle with a white cross on it and a hood. But I'm still not grasping what's happening because I am totally amazed by this hood and the buttonhole stitching around the eyes of the hood. I was like, **You know, maybe I should take up sewing ...**

And then I looked down the hallway, and the woman is still looking at me. So I thought, ***OK. I'm just going to sit here. And oh! There's a table and a book. Hooray!***

So I'm flipping through the book, and it looks like a Bible

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because it's got gilt lettering on the outside, and I thought, ***Oh great! It's a Bible! I know that! Corinthians, Ephesians; Proverbs for wisdom, Psalms if you're sad.*** So I'm trying to look for something peaceful and happy to read, and instead I come across this horrible-looking manifesto that talks about the superiority of the white race and how we need to annihilate everyone but them for their own safety. And I shut the book.

And it finally hits me that I am in the home of an honest-to-Ggod Klansman, and I am black. And I look down the hallway at this woman, and she's looking back at me like, ***Do you get this now?*** And I'm like, ***Oh shit!***

And then right at this moment, the mousse starts coming up out of this man's mouth and nose again, and I think, ***Thank God! I've got something to do, I've got something to do!***

So I run over to this man, and I'm cleaning him up, very calm and professional - - cleaning, cleaning! But inside my mind, I'm like, ***Oh my God! I'm so glad he's not conscious, he probably hates me and, you know, I don't hate him personally, but my people hate him.*** And I'm feeling all this anxiety, and then I think, ***You cannot do this right now be-***

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cause you need a job, OK? You do not have time for a Rosa Parks moment. You have to get through this. OK? I'm an overachiever. I can do this. I am not going to let a little racism stand in my way. I am going to get this done, I am going to do it well, I am going to get an A+, I am going to get a check, and I am going to get the *hell* out of here, OK!?!

And that is exactly what I did. I did it every fifteen minutes for four hours that day. For ***four*** hours. And I came back the next day. She opened the door, and she wasn't quite as unfriendly. I guess she recognized that I was not going to kill the man. And I came back the third day -- she was so tired, and I realized that this woman was not getting any rest unless I was there to take care of him; that nobody would come to save her, or help her, which was really sad.

By the fourth day, she just came to the door and immediately lay down, and I did the job. I had to wake her up at the end of that four hours. And then on the fifth day, the temp agency called me *(picks up the phone),* and said, "We don't need you anymore." The man had passed away. But the lady had called to leave me a message.

She wanted me to know that I'd given him the best care

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that he'd had since he left the hospital, and the most peace and rest that she got was when I was there, and she wanted to thank me personally. And I thought, ***Man, that is amazing***. And she left me a tip, which the temp agency would not let me keep.

But a few months later, I realized I really did get a tip and it was this: the knowledge that we had come together, she and I, these two incredibly desperate people in a highly charged situation. And it could have been a train wreck; it could have been a mess. But instead, we came together, and our lives touched, and in that touching we changed the trajectory of our lives just a little bit.

I'd like to think that I changed the way that she thought about people of color -- that we weren't whatever it was that those people were teaching her, and that she might reconsider her prejudices. And for myself, I got a job that I desperately needed. I had left Indiana to change the world. And I didn't; I couldn't. But I realized that even if I couldn't change the world, I could change the little piece of the world that I was in, and that was enough for me.

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AWARD HISTORY

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